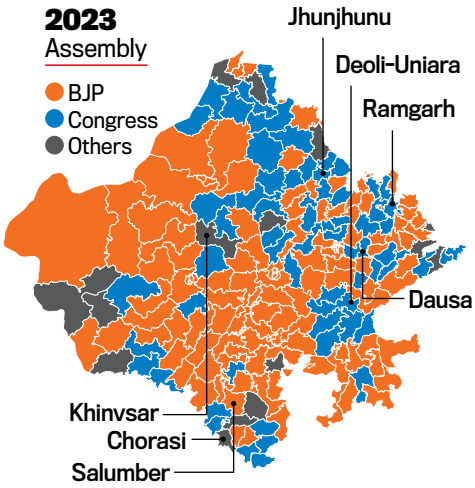


of soft accommodation rather than military-style command and control.

Meanwhile, former rebels Rajendra Bhamboo and Sukhvant Singh are seeking to reclaim their political fortunes after returning to the saffron fold. Bhamboo is up against the Congress's Amit Ola, son of Brijendra Singh Ola, who vacated the Jhunjhunu seat after getting elected as MP. Sukhvant has been fielded against the Congress's Aryan Khan, who is trying to retain Ramgarh, which fell vacant following his father Zubair Khan's death. The BJP, too, is trying to appeal to voters emotionally, having fielded the late Amrit Lal Meena's wife Shanti Devi from Salumber.

The byelections will also serve as a crucial test of the BJP's organisational strength under its new state president Madan Rathore. With candidate selections sparking disaffection, both Sharma and Rathore are engaged in damage control. The role of former chief minister Vasundhara Raje and her supporters adds another layer of uncertainty to the campaign dynamics. If the BJP underperforms, it could lead to calls for a leadership change, opening the door for other ambitious figures within the party to vie for prominence. That's the last thing Sharma would want ahead of the big-ticket investment summit in Jaipur. ■

MADHYA PRADESH/ MILK COOPERATIVES

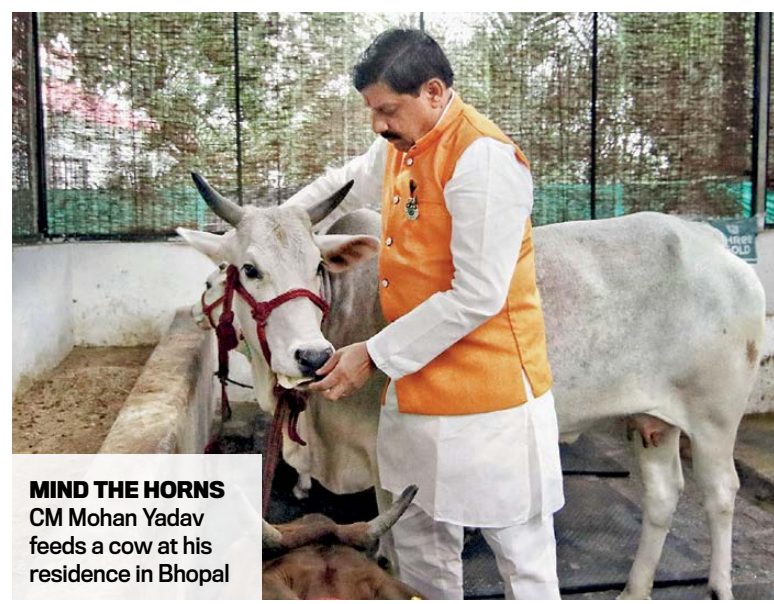
NOT SO UTTERLY BUTTERLY

By Rahul Noronha

Forget cow politics, even milk has reached boiling point in Madhya Pradesh. The trigger: the state government's decision to hand over control of the MP State Cooperative Dairy Federation (MPCDF) to the National Dairy Development Board (NDDB) for five years has come under fire. The cooperatives department has almost finalised the modalities of the transfer, after which an MoU will be signed between the two entities. The move has attracted criticism from the opposition Congress which alleges it is to facilitate the 'backdoor entry' of Amul into the state and swamp inhouse brand 'Sanchi'.

Madhya Pradesh is the third largest producer of milk in the country, after UP and Rajasthan, and there is immense scope for growth in the sector. Officially, the state government maintains the decision to hand over management and operational control to the NDDB is to strengthen the Sanchi brand, make it competitive and infuse fresh life into it. But why now? Well, the annual turnover of the state's milk cooperatives stands at Rs 2,200 crore and insiders claim there has been little growth in the past few years. The state dairy cooperative collects around 1.05 million kg of milk every day, but collection has not been increasing as expected.

Currently, the milk cooperative sector in MP has a three-tier structure, pertaining to milk aggregation. The dairy cooperative societies at the outermost layer mostly collect milk from around 11,000 villages while, in the second tier, the milk unions located in Bhopal, Indore, Ujjain, Sagar, Jabalpur and



MIND THE HORNS CM Mohan Yadav feeds a cow at his residence in Bhopal

ANI